

DBS Group Holdings

First Take: A beat, and guidance better-than-feared

Our First Take: DBS announced 1Q25 net income of S\$2.9bn, down 2% y/y, 15% q/q, and 3% above JPMe. Results indicate strong delivery across business lines, with PPoP up 7% y/y and 7% above our estimates. NII saw a modest 1% q/q decline, with NIM down 3bps q/q, but this is largely expected given the YTD decline in SORA. Non-II grew 9% y/y and 25% q/q, with WM fees and AUM reaching new highs, and strong pick-up in loan fees offsetting weaker card fees. Costs declined 8% q/q, largely on non-staff costs. The bank booked an additional 20bps GP as a “prudent measure” with SPs low in the quarter at 10bps ann; this led to NPA cover moving up to 137% from 129% in the previous quarter. DPS is in line with guidance at 75c. The most important takeaway from results and commentary is resilient guidance. This was a key worry getting into 1Q numbers, given lower S\$ rates YTD and trade uncertainty. In fact, DBS is looking at opportunities during this period, while acknowledging risks. This is similar to discussions with UOB yesterday. The overnight comments from the Fed also help the H4L US\$ rate thesis, at least for now. SORA is down sharply YTD, and is a risk, which is reasonably well-flagged. In next 6M, the key risks include AQ deterioration, sharp NIM decline, and a rethink on capital management. All these have held up well in 1Q and April, with no meaningful shift in payout being flagged. We expect the stock to stay firm, especially within the Singapore/DM Asia banks context. Maintain OW.

2025 Guidance

- Three rate cuts vs. two previously, but NII still above 2024
- Commercial book non-II growth at mid to high single digit (from high single digit previously)
- CIR unchanged at low 40% range
- SP unchanged at 17-20bps
- Net profit below 2024, mainly due to 15% global minimum tax

Key Positives

Fee income grew 22% y/y, with strength across WM and loan-related fees. AUM reached a new record high at S\$432bn (+S\$6bn q/q). Costs were managed well, with CIR declining to 37%. NPA coverage has moved up to 137% (230% of unsecured NPA).

Key Negatives/Question Marks

Limited negatives from results, though some drivers of the 1Q strength such as WM and loan fees may not be sustainable, especially in a scenario of weaker economic growth.

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Overweight

DBSM.SI, DBS SP

Price (07 May 25): S\$42.76

Price Target (Dec-25): S\$49.00

**FIRST
TAKE**



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Likely Changes to Consensus

We expect small positive revisions post results.

Expected Stock Reaction

We expect the stock to move up.

Conference call details

DBS is hosting a media briefing today at 10:30AM HKT and analyst briefing at 11:30AM HKT.

Table 1: DBS: 1Q25 earnings review

P&L (\$mn)	1Q24	2Q24	3Q24	4Q24	1Q25A	1Q25E	YoY	QoQ	JPMe
Net Interest Income	3,505	3,594	3,597	3,728	3,681	3,653	5%	-1%	1%
Non-Interest Income	2,103	1,951	2,222	1,847	2,301	2,154	9%	25%	7%
Net Fee Income	1,043	1,048	1,109	968	1,275	1,123	22%	32%	14%
Other Non-interest Income	1,060	903	1,113	879	1,026	1,031	-3%	17%	-1%
Operating Revenue	5,608	5,545	5,819	5,575	5,982	5,808	7%	7%	3%
Operating Costs	(2,079)	(2,172)	(2,249)	(2,395)	(2,214)	(2,271)	6%	-8%	-2%
PPOP	3,529	3,373	3,570	3,180	3,768	3,537	7%	18%	7%
Provisions	(135)	(160)	(136)	(214)	(325)	(223)	141%	52%	46%
Pre-Tax	3,394	3,213	3,434	2,966	3,443	3,314	1%	16%	4%
Core Attributable Profit	2,956	2,803	3,027	2,622	2,897	2,811	-2%	10%	3%
Net Attributable Profit	2,951	2,789	3,027	2,522	2,897	2,811	-2%	15%	3%
DPS (\$)	0.54	0.54	0.54	0.60	0.75	0.75	39%	25%	0%
Gross Loans	431,000	430,912	424,000	436,684	442,000	440,643	3%	1%	0%
Net Loans	424,833	424,837	418,068	430,594	435,295	434,509	2%	1%	0%
Deposits	547,197	551,088	544,961	561,730	575,663	561,570	5%	2%	3%
NPA	5,221	5,077	4,680	5,036	4,861	5,167	-7%	-3%	-6%
							Change in bps		
NIM	2.14%	2.14%	2.11%	2.15%	2.12%	2.12%	(2)	(3)	0
CIR	37.1%	39.2%	38.6%	43.0%	37.0%	39.1%	(6)	(595)	(209)
LDR	78.8%	78.2%	77.8%	77.7%	76.8%	78.5%	(198)	(96)	(169)
CASA Ratio	51.2%	50.5%	51.7%	51.8%	53.0%	51.3%	183	118	169
Total Provisions/Gross Loans (bps)	13	15	13	20	30	20	17	10	9
NPL Ratio	1.10%	1.10%	1.00%	1.09%	1.10%	1.11%	0	1	(1)
(Total allowances + RLAR)/NPA	125%	129%	135%	129%	137%	127%	1,199	765	1,008
CET1 (Fully phased-in)	14.7%	14.8%	15.2%	15.1%	15.2%	15.3%	48	6	(8)
CET1 (Transitory)	14.7%	14.8%	17.2%	17.0%	17.4%	17.1%	270	251	227

Source: Company reports, J.P. Morgan estimates.

DBS Group Holdings (Overweight; Price Target: S\$49.00)

Investment Thesis

We hold OW on DBS.

- The bank's commitment to and delivery of payouts in numerous forms (progressively increasing regular dividends, bonus shares and buyback) allows investors to pay a multiple for the income stream. Hence, until the sum of BVPSg and dividend yield does not go below ~10%, we expect the stock to keep moving up.
- DBS is positioned to deliver S\$11bn profits each year over next 3Y, despite potential decline in NIM with lower rates. WM continues to drive non-II, and asset quality appears intact. We expect 9/7bps annual decline in NIM 2025/26E. The bank has reduced rate-sensitivity of NIM over the next few years, helping improve capital generation visibility.
- DBS has delivered one of the best ROE expansions in the last decade as high rates and technology-led changes across the franchise led to improvements in growth, efficiency, and returns. The bank's digital strength is driving gains in loan market share, WM, as well as underwriting, which had previously seen challenges at the bank.
- Any indication of a pick-up in NPL formation would be a catalyst for de-rating. A key risk area could be CRE, where DBS has exposure of S\$90bn (21% of loans), of which S\$18bn is in HK (4% of loans). Yet, if the bank is able to manage AQ well over the course of 2025-26, the stock would continue to re-rate, in our view.

Valuation

Our Dec-25 PT of S\$49 is based on a fair P/B of 1.89x, assuming a normalized RoE of 16.1%, a risk-free rate of 4.2%, a cost of capital of 9.2% and a growth rate of 1.50%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Upside catalysts include: (1) further increases in payout; (2) resilient GDP growth, leading to better-than-expected growth and asset quality; (3) sustained improvements in underwriting and monitoring, leading to lower-than-expected credit costs; (4) better-than-expected efficiency gains due to digital investments; and (5) better than expected WM performance.

Downside risks include: (1) dividend disappointment; (2) asset quality deterioration; and (3) faster and/or larger Fed rate cuts or decline in SORA, which would drive a larger than expected NIM compression.

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DBS Group Holdings (DBSM.SI, DBS SP) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Dec 11, 2001. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

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